Topic 18 — International Environmental Agreements & Conferences

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Conferences: Stockholm 1972 (स्टॉकहोम सम्मेलन) | Brundtland Commission | Rio 1992 | Agenda 21 | SD conferences **Treaties:** CBD | UNFCCC (यूएनएफसीसीसी) | Kyoto (क्योटो) | Paris | Montreal | Ramsar (रामसर) | CITES (साइट्स) | CMS | Vienna | Basel | Rotterdam | Stockholm POPs | Minamata

Sources baked in: UNEP, UNFCCC, CBD Secretariat, Ramsar, CITES, NCERT, MoEFCC, UPPCS PYQs 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ High — Montreal ≠ Kyoto, Agenda 21 = 1992, treaty ↔ issue matching **Last verified:** August 2026

Current Affairs (this topic)

- COP outcomes and new listings refresh CA; treaty years and Montreal≠Kyoto stay fixed.
- Ramsar / CITES / CMS updates — verify live lists; UP Ramsar baseline remains **12**.

18.1 Conferences — Stockholm, Brundtland, Rio, Agenda 21 & SD Summits

Identity: UNEP 1972 | SD definition 1987 | Rio triple outcome 1992 | Agenda 21 trap | Earth Summit +5 | Rio+20



- The **Stockholm Conference (1972)** (स्टॉकहोम सम्मेलन) was the first major UN conference on the **human environment**. - Its theme was **"Only One Earth"** and it adopted (अंगीकृत) the **Stockholm Declaration** with 26 principles. - Stockholm led to creation of **UNEP** with headquarters in **Nairobi, Kenya**. - **World Environment Day** is celebrated on **5 June** every year, marking the Stockholm opening day.



- The **Brundtland Commission (WCED)** published ***Our Common Future*** in **1987** with the classic **sustainable development** definition. - The Brundtland Report is **not** *The Limits to Growth* (Club of Rome, 1972). - Chronology often tested: ***Limits to Growth*** **(1972)** → **Brundtland Report (1987)** (ब्रंटलैंड रिपोर्ट) → **Montreal Protocol enforcement (January 1989)** → **Rio Earth Summit (June 1992)**. - Montreal was **signed in September 1987**; papers that say “enforcement” mean **January 1989**.



- The **Rio Earth Summit (1992)** (रियो पृथ्वी शिखर सम्मेलन 1992) or **UNCED** produced the **Rio Declaration**, opened **UNFCCC** and **CBD** for signature, and adopted **Agenda 21**. - **Agenda 21** is a non-binding action plan for **sustainable development in the 21st century** — adopted at **Rio 1992**, not 1995. - Agenda 21 is a large multi-chapter blueprint (about **40 chapters** in **4 sections** / groupings) — bank stems sometimes say "4 agreements." - **Local Agenda 21** encourages cities and local bodies to prepare their own SD plans. - The **Commission on Sustainable Development (CSD)** was created to monitor Earth Summit implementation. - **Earth Summit +5** was the UN General Assembly special session (पंगु सत्र) held in **New York in June 1997** to review Rio progress. - **Johannesburg Summit (2002)** was Rio+10 on sustainable development and reaffirmed Agenda 21. - **Rio+20 (2012)** — the United Nations Conference on Sustainable Development — reviewed SD progress and produced the outcome document ***The Future We Want***. - **PAGE (Partnership for Action on Green Economy (हरित अर्थव्यवस्था))** was created as the UN response to Rio+20's call for green-economy transitions. - **SDGs were adopted in 2015** at the UN General Assembly. - The **Global Environment Facility (GEF)** (जीईएफ) was established in **1991** on the eve of Rio to finance global environmental projects. - GEF is a financial mechanism for five major

conventions: **Minamata** (mercury), **Stockholm POPs**, **CBD**, **UNCCD**, and **UNFCCC**. - Key implementing partners include **UNDP** (यूएनडीपी), **UNEP**, and the **World Bank**. GEF also supports tools such as the **Least Developed Countries Fund (LDCF)** for National Adaptation Programmes of Action.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q51

(A) SD should not compromise future generations' needs. (R) Agenda 21 was signed in 1995.

Show answer

Ans: C — Agenda 21 = **Rio 1992**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q132

Agenda-21 of Rio Summit (1992) is related to:

A. Sustainable Development

B. Polluter Pays

C. Environmental Education (पर्यावरण शिक्षा)

D. Ozone Layer

Show answer

Ans: A

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q51

Brundtland Report is also known as *The Limits to Growth*?

Show answer

Ans: D (A true, R false) — Brundtland = *Our Common Future* (1987).

Conference	Year	Key output
Stockholm	1972	UNEP, WED 5 June
Limits to Growth	1972	Club of Rome study
Brundtland	1987	SD definition
Montreal enforcement	Jan 1989	ODS phase-out starts
Rio	1992	UNFCCC, CBD, Agenda 21
Earth Summit +5	1997	Rio progress review (NY)
Johannesburg	2002	Rio+10
Rio+20	2012	*The Future We Want*; PAGE
SDGs	2015	17 goals, 2030 deadline

18.2 Climate Treaties — UNFCCC, Kyoto Protocol & Paris Agreement

Identity: UNFCCC 1992 framework | Kyoto 1997 binding Annex-I | Paris 2015 NDCs

- The **UNFCCC** was opened for signature at **Rio 1992** to stabilize greenhouse gas concentrations.
- UNFCCC holds annual **COP** meetings. The secretariat is in **Bonn, Germany**.
- The **Kyoto Protocol (1997)** (क्योटो प्रोटोकॉल) set **legally binding emission reduction targets** for **Annex-I (developed) countries**. It entered into force on **16 February 2005**.
- Kyoto introduced **Clean Development Mechanism (CDM)** carbon credits and **Emissions Trading**. CDM projects run in **developing countries**; **1 CER ≈ 1 tCO_2**.
- The **Green Climate Fund (GCF)** (जीसीएफ) was established at **Cancun COP-16 (2010)** under UNFCCC — not at Durban.
- **Earth Hour** (अर्थ आवर) is a **WWF** (डब्ल्यूडब्ल्यूएफ) climate-awareness event (usually last Saturday of March). **GHG Protocol** = **WRI + WBCSD**.



- The **Paris Agreement (2015)** (पेरिस समझौता) at **COP21** applies to **all countries** through **Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs)**.
- Paris aims to limit warming to **well below 2°C**, pursuing **1.5°C**.
- Paris entered into force in **2016**. It is **not identical** to Kyoto's binding annex-only model.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q35

Which agreement relates to climate change (जलवायु परिवर्तन) mitigation?

A. Montreal Protocol

B. Ramsar

C. Kyoto Protocol

D. CITES

Show answer

Ans: C — Montreal = **ozone**, not climate.

Treaty	Year	Model
UNFCCC	1992	Framework
Kyoto	1997	Binding Annex-I targets
Paris	2015	Universal NDCs

> **Key fact:Montreal** = ozone/ODS phase-out (this section). **UNFCCC–Paris** = climate/NDC framework (see climate-change chapters). India's **NAPCC** and **NDC** pledges sit under national climate policy, not the Montreal ozone regime.

18.3 Ozone Treaties — Vienna Convention & Montreal Protocol

Identity: Vienna 1985 framework | Montreal 1987 ODS phase-out | Kigali 2016 HFCs

- The **Vienna Convention (1985)** (वियना कन्वेंशन) created the framework to protect the **ozone layer**.
- The **Montreal Protocol (1987)** (मॉन्ट्रियल प्रोटोकॉल) set **binding schedules** to phase out **ozone-depleting substances (ODS)** like CFCs.
- Montreal is the **most successful environmental treaty** — universal ratification, ODS emissions down ~99%.
- **International Ozone Day** is **16 September** (Montreal signing date).
- The **Kigali Amendment (2016)** (किगाली संशोधन) phases down **HFCs** under the Montreal framework.
- Montreal controls **ozone/ODS** — **not climate change mitigation** trap logic.

> **Logic:** Full ozone chemistry and Antarctic hole → **Topic 11**.

18.4 Biodiversity & Species Treaties — CBD, CITES, CMS & Ramsar

Identity: CBD 1992 three objectives | CITES trade | CMS migration | Ramsar wetlands

CBD

- The **Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD)** was opened at **Rio 1992**.
- Its three objectives are **conservation**, **sustainable use**, and **fair benefit-sharing (ABS)**.
- The **Cartagena Protocol** covers **biosafety** for living modified organisms.
- **TRAFFIC** (WWF–IUCN alliance) monitors wildlife trade for sustainability — it is **not** a UNEP bureau.
- **BirdLife International** identifies Important Bird and Biodiversity Areas; biodiversity **hotspots** were framed by **Norman Myers**, not BirdLife.
- The **Nagoya Protocol (2010)** implements **Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS)**.
- India implemented CBD through the **Biological Diversity Act, 2002**.

CITES

- **CITES (1973, Washington)** regulates **international trade** in endangered wild fauna (प्राणीजात) and flora (वनस्पति).
- **Appendix I** — trade banned except in exceptional cases.
- **Appendix II** — regulated trade with permits.
- **Appendix III** — species listed by a member country requesting cooperation.

CMS (Bonn Convention) (बॉन कन्वेंशन)

- The **Convention on Migratory Species (1979)** protects **migratory species** and their flyways across borders.
- CMS focuses on **habitat (वास स्थान) and migration routes**, not commercial trade like CITES.

Ramsar

- The **Ramsar Convention (1971)** (रामसर कन्वेंशन) conserves **wetlands** through the **"Wise Use"** principle.
- **World Wetlands Day** is **2 February**.
- India has about **100** Ramsar sites; state ranks often tested are **Tamil Nadu (नाडु) 16**, **Uttar Pradesh 10**, **Punjab 6**.
- The **Montreux Record** lists Ramsar sites where ecological character has changed or may change from human interference.
- India has many Ramsar sites including several in **UP**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q58

Which Ramsar sites are **NOT** in Uttar Pradesh?

1. Sarsai Nawar 2. Samaspur 3. Rudrasagar 4. Sultanpur

Show answer

Ans: B (3 and 4) — Rudrasagar (Tripura); Sultanpur (Haryana).

Treaty	Issue	Year
CBD	Biodiversity	1992
CITES	Species **trade**	1973
CMS	**Migratory** species	1979
Ramsar	**Wetlands**	1971

18.5 Chemicals & Waste Treaties — Basel, Rotterdam, Stockholm POPs & Minamata

Identity: Basel waste | Rotterdam PIC chemicals | Stockholm POPs | Minamata mercury

- The **Basel Convention (1989)** (बासेल कन्वेंशन) controls **transboundary movement of hazardous waste**.
- It aims to prevent developed countries from dumping hazardous waste in developing countries.
- The **Rotterdam Convention (1998)** (रॉटरडैम कन्वेंशन) implements **Prior Informed Consent (PIC)** for trade in **hazardous chemicals**.
- The **Stockholm Convention on POPs (2001)** targets **persistent organic pollutants** like **DDT and PCBs** that remain in the environment.
- The **Minamata Convention (2013)** (मिनामाता संधि) controls **mercury** mining, use, emissions, and releases.
- It is named after **Minamata disease** from mercury poisoning in Japan.

Treaty	Targets
Basel	Hazardous **waste** shipment
Rotterdam	Hazardous **chemicals** trade (PIC)
Stockholm POPs	Persistent organic pollutants
Minamata	**Mercury**